THE HAPPINESS ISSUE



# FACTORY OF START-UPS

## Migrant workers have become successful entrepreneurs creating a **business and employment model** that is now being emulated across the state

**By AMITABH SRIVASTAVA** *in West Champaran*

**As Archana Kushwaha walks across the giant computer-enabled embroidery machine, overseeing the transfer of intricate designs onto the fabric displayed on the monitor, she places a call to the automobile service station where she had sent her car the day before. "How can a car worth Rs 17 lakh, purchased just last year, give trouble? Fix it before the weekend," demands the 32-year-old owner of a manufacturing unit that produces designer saris and lehengas in Bihar's West Champaran district.**

It's been a busy day for Archana and her husband Nand Kishore Kushwaha, 38. While Archana is covering the 3,000 sq. ft workspace, monitoring the production process, Nand Kishore is taking orders from the retailers on the phone. "The upcoming marriage season is fuelling the demand," he says. Having posted revenue of Rs 2.83 crore in the past financial year, the couple is optimistic about even better returns this year. Not only do they exude the image of a successful business couple, but Archana and Nand Kishore also embody a compelling life-turnaround story.

Till March 2020, they jointly earned Rs 70,000 a month at Surat where Nand Kishore managed the operation of industrial sewing machines, while Archana worked as a tailor. However, the onset of the Covid-19 pandemic rendered them jobless. Struggling through the challenges, the couple managed to survive without any income for a couple of months. Subsequently, they decided to return to their native West Champaran district.

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